UNIT 3

Gender and Labour

division of labour • housework • unpaid work • development • governance • rights • mainstreaming

1. Division and Valuation of Labour

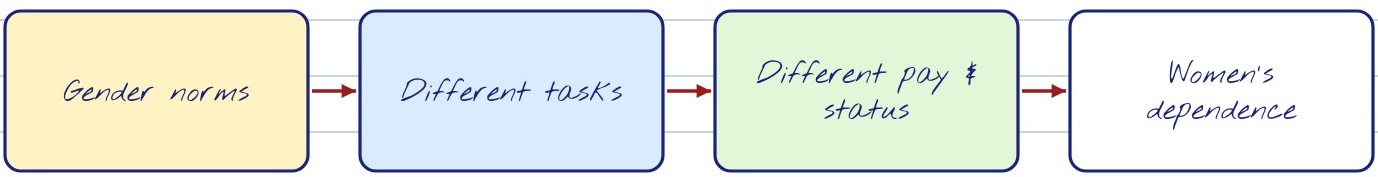
Sexual (gender) division of labour = allocation of different tasks to women and men on the basis of gender, not skill. Tasks done by men are usually **paid, public and valued**, tasks done by women are **unpaid, private and undervalued**.

Q1. Explain the gender division of labour and the valuation of work.

Ans. Society splits work into "productive" (earning) and "reproductive" (caring) and then values them unequally.

- Women do most of cooking, cleaning, child care, elder care, fetching water and fuel.
- Men do most paid work outside, are considered "workers" and "heads".
- Women's work in farms, family business and home is called "help", not work.
- **Same work, different pay** : women get lower wages and are concentrated in low-paid, insecure jobs (domestic work, beedi rolling, agriculture labour).

Type of work	Mostly done by	Valued as
Paid job, business	Men	Productive, respected
Housework and care	Women	"Natural duty", no pay
Farm work on family land	Women and men	Women = "helper"
Domestic help, nursing	Women	Low-paid "women's jobs"



Key terms

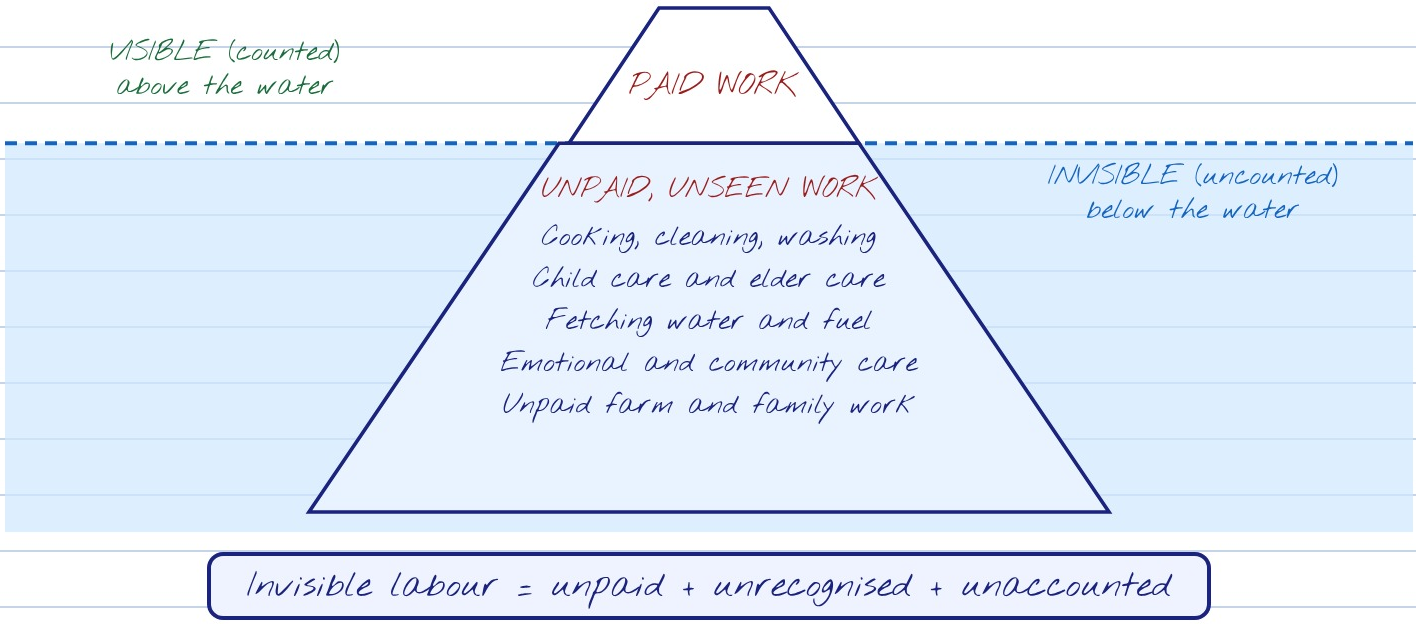
- **Horizontal segregation** : women crowded in certain jobs (teaching, nursing, garment).
- **Vertical segregation** : women at lower levels - the **glass ceiling** blocks top posts.
- **Feminisation of labour** : women entering insecure, informal, low-wage work.
- **Gender wage gap** : women earn less than men for equal work.

2. Housework: The Invisible Labour

Q2. Why is housework called "invisible labour"?

Ans. Because it is unpaid, unrecorded in GDP, assumed to be women's love and duty, and done inside the home.

- Includes : cooking, cleaning, washing, child and elder care, shopping, managing the family, emotional care.
- Takes **long hours** (women spend several times more time on unpaid domestic work than men - Time Use Survey 2019).
- Leaves women **time-poor** : less time for education, paid jobs, rest, politics.
- Economic value is huge but not counted in national income.



Invisible labour = unpaid + unrecognised + unaccounted

3. "My Mother Doesn't Work."

Theme (textbook essay) : when asked "does your mother work?", children say "No, she is a housewife" - though she works from dawn to night. This shows how society defines **work = paid employment**.

Q3. Discuss the statement "My mother doesn't work."

Ans. It reflects the belief that only income-earning activity is work, so homemakers' labour becomes invisible and valueless.

- Mother's daily work : cooking, cleaning, care of children, elders, animals, guests - 12 to 16 hours.
- Because she gets no wage, she is seen as dependent and "not working".
- Census and surveys earlier classed housewives as "non-workers" or "dependants".
- **Lesson** : redefine work to include care work; give dignity, respect and economic recognition.

What recognition can look like

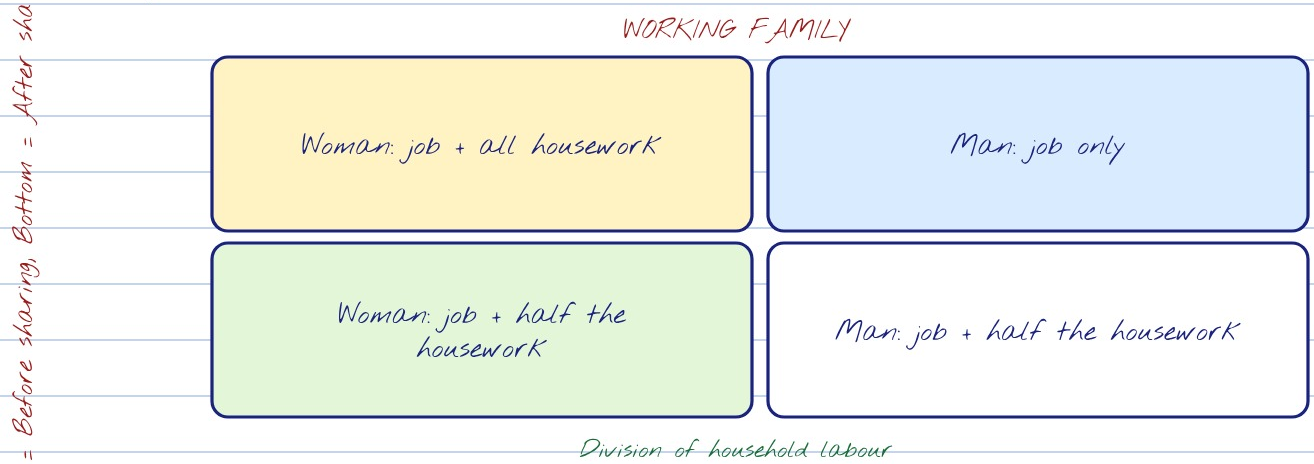
- Counting unpaid work in time-use surveys and satellite accounts of GDP.
- Social security, pension and health cover for homemakers.
- Respect and shared decisions at home, equal property rights.

4. "Share the Load."

Q4. What is meant by "Share the Load"? Why is it needed?

Ans. A call for men and boys to share housework and care equally so that the burden does not fall only on women.

- Working women face the **double burden** (job + home) or **triple burden** (+ community).
- Sharing improves women's health, career, leisure and equality; children learn respect.
- Men gain closer bonds with children and family and are freed from the "sole provider" pressure.



Q5. How can the load be shared? (Practical steps)

- Teach boys and girls the same life skills (cooking, cleaning, care).
- Make a family roster of daily chores, use technology and shared services.
- Paternity leave, flexible work, creches at workplace, change attitudes ("helping" -> "responsibility").

5. Work: Its Politics and Economics - Fact and Fiction

Q6. Explain the politics and economics of work. Distinguish fact and fiction.

Ans. **Economics** : who is paid, how much, and what counts in GDP. **Politics** : who has the power to define work, set wages and control resources.

Fiction (myth)	Fact
Women's work is only supplementary income	Women are often main or sole earners
Women don't want to work outside	Lack of safe jobs, creches, transport and family support
Women are less productive	Equal output, they face career breaks and bias
Housework is not real work	It sustains the economy; value is huge
Men are always the breadwinners	Many women-headed households exist

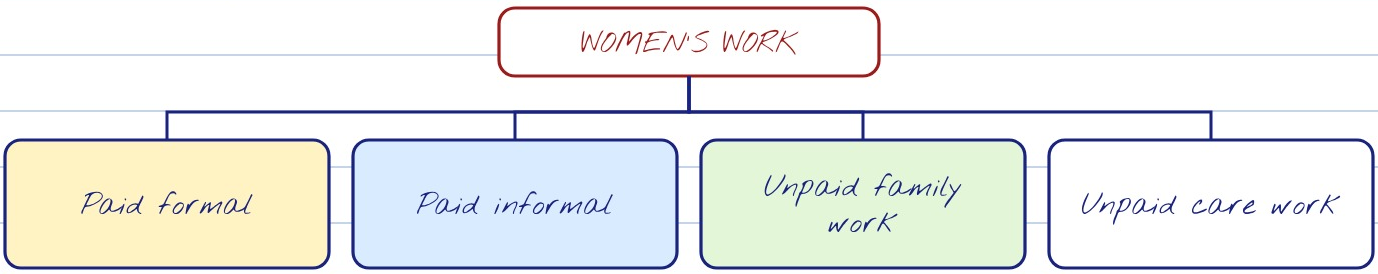
- Most women work in the **informal sector** (agriculture, domestic work, home-based) with no contract, no social security.
- National income accounts ignore unpaid work -> women's contribution is under-estimated.
- Equal pay is legally guaranteed (Equal Remuneration Act 1976, now Code on Wages 2019) but gaps persist.

6. Unrecognised and Unaccounted Work

Q7. What is unrecognised and unaccounted work? Give examples.

Ans. Work that is done but not recognised as work in law or society (unrecognised) and not included in national statistics (unaccounted).

- Housework, child and elder care, volunteer community service.
- Unpaid labour on family farm or in family shop, collecting fuel, fodder and water.
- Home-based piece-rate work (beedi, agarbatti, embroidery) counted as "hobby".
- Subsistence production, Kitchen gardens, rearing livestock.



Recommendations

- Time-use surveys (India's first national Time Use Survey 2019), satellite accounts.
- Registration of home-based and domestic workers, minimum wages, social security.
- Maternity Benefit (Amendment) Act 2017 : 26 weeks paid leave, creche for 50 or more employees.

7. Gender Development Issues

Q8. What are the main gender development issues? Name the gender indices.

Ans. Gender gaps in education, health, income, work and power slow human development.

- **Education** : lower female literacy, drop-outs, fewer girls in STEM.
- **Health** : anaemia, maternal mortality, low nutrition, unequal care.
- **Economic** : low workforce participation, wage gap, no land or asset ownership.
- **Political** : under-representation in legislatures and leadership.
- **Safety** : violence, trafficking, harassment.

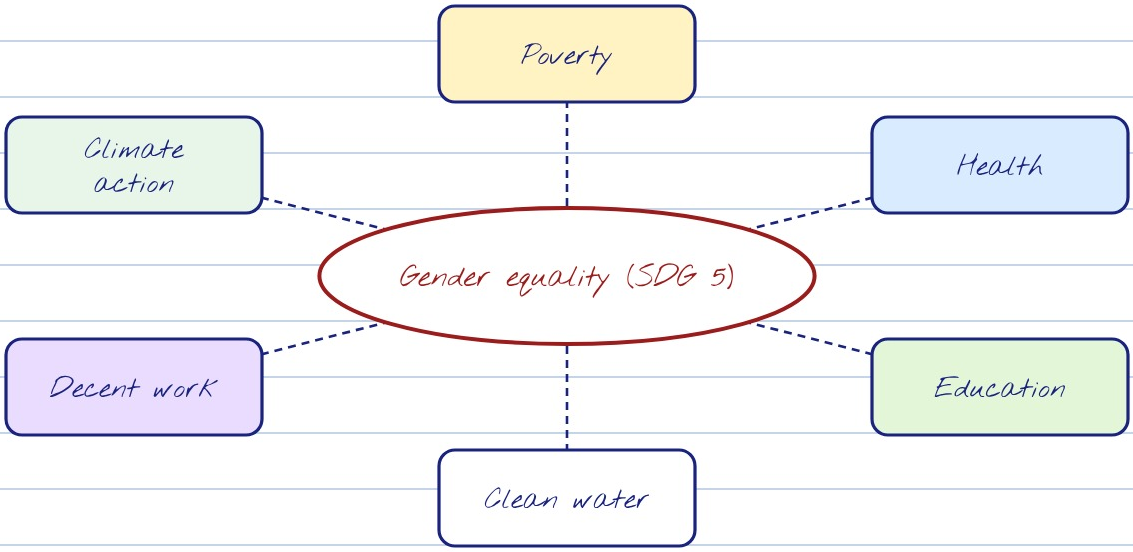
Index	Full form and what it measures
HDI	Human Development Index – health, education, income
GDI	Gender Development Index – HDI gap between women and men
GII	Gender Inequality Index – reproductive health, empowerment, labour market
GEM	Gender Empowerment Measure – political and economic participation
Global Gender Gap Index	World Economic Forum – economy, education, health, politics

8. Gender, Governance and Sustainable Development

Q9. How are gender, governance and sustainable development related?

Ans. Good governance needs equal participation of women; sustainable development is impossible without gender equality (**SDG 5**).

- **Governance** : women in decision-making make policies sensitive to health, water, school, safety.
- 73rd and 74th Amendments (1992–93) : 33 per cent (now 50 per cent in many states) seats in Panchayats and Municipalities.
- **Women's Reservation Act, 2023 (Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam)** : one-third seats for women in Lok Sabha and State Assemblies.
- **Sustainability** : women manage water, forests, seeds and food; Chipko, Green Belt movement.
- Gender budgeting and gender audits make public money reach women.



9. Gender and Human Rights

Q10. Explain gender and human rights. Mention important instruments.

Ans. Women's rights are human rights - universal, indivisible, equal.

- **UDHR 1948** : all human beings are born free and equal.
- **CEDAW 1979** : "Bill of Rights for Women"; India ratified in 1993.
- **Vienna Declaration 1993** : women's rights are inseparable part of human rights.
- **DEVAW 1993** : UN Declaration on Elimination of Violence against Women.
- **Beijing Platform for Action 1995** : 12 critical areas, mainstreaming.
- In India : Fundamental Rights (Art. 14, 15, 21), Directive Principles, special laws.



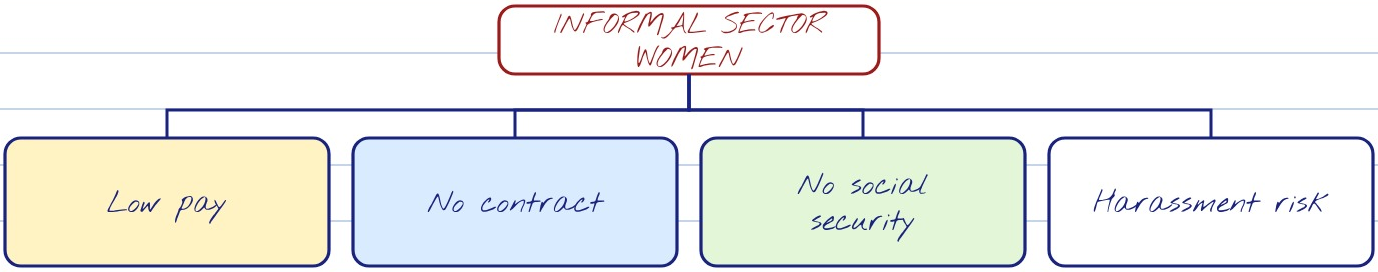
10. Women in the Labour Force: Informal Sector

Q11. Describe the position of women workers in the informal sector.

Ans. Most working women in India are in the unorganised sector - agriculture, construction, domestic work, home-based work, street vending - with low pay and no protection.

- No written contract, no fixed hours, no paid leave, no pension or maternity cover.
- Often paid piece-rate and less than men; unsafe work places; sexual harassment.
- Domestic workers : long hours, no weekly off, low wages, abuse; recent laws and welfare boards try to protect them.

- Self-help groups (SEWA, Kudumbashree, SHGs) organise women for credit, skills and voice.



Legal protections for working women

- Equal Remuneration Act 1976 and Code on Wages 2019 : equal pay for equal or similar work.
- Maternity Benefit Act 1961 (2017 amendment) : 26 weeks leave, creche, work from home option.
- Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace Act (POSH) 2013 : Internal Committee.
- Factories Act : safety, restrictions on night shifts only with safeguards.
- Unorganised Workers Social Security Act 2008; Domestic workers welfare schemes.

Q12. What is gender budgeting?

Ans. Analysis of government budgets to see their effect on women and men and allocating funds to close gaps.

- Started in India 2005-06 : Gender Budget Statement, Gender Budget Cells in ministries.
- Part A : schemes 100 per cent for women; Part B : at least 30 per cent for women.

Q13. Case study - "Meena, a domestic worker"

- Works 10 hours in four houses, paid below minimum wage, no leave, and does her own housework at night.
- Identify : informal sector, double burden, invisible work, wage gap.
- Suggest : registration and minimum wage, weekly off, social security, shared housework at her home, union support.

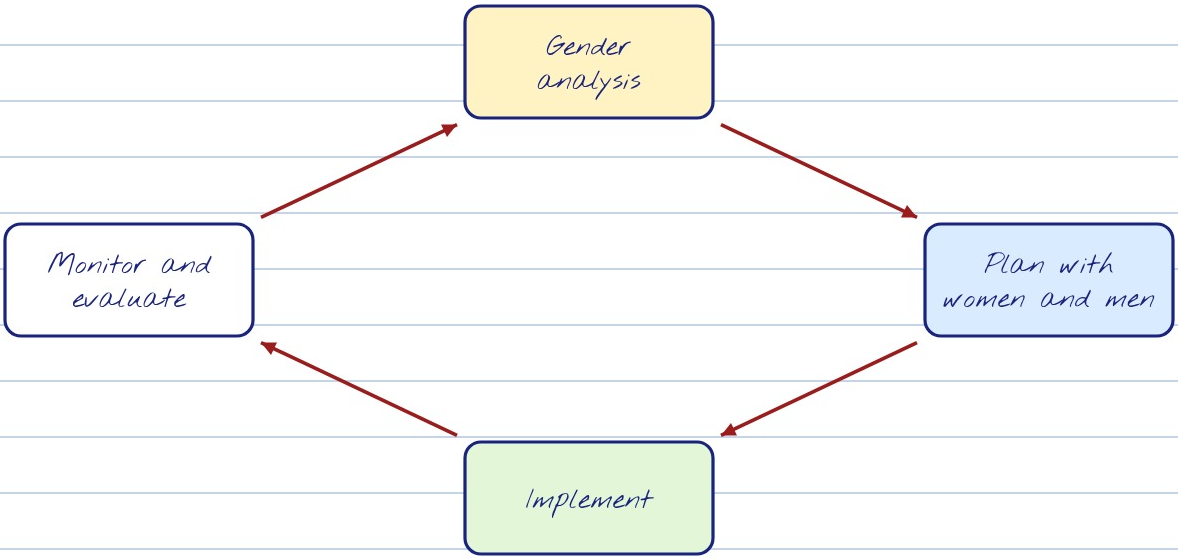
II. Gender Mainstreaming

Q14. What is gender mainstreaming? State its strategies.

Ans. ECOSOC (1997) : the process of assessing implications for women and men of any planned action, law, policy or programme, and making women's and men's concerns an integral dimension of all spheres so that **inequality is not perpetuated**.

- Gender analysis of every policy, budget and project before it is made.

- Gender budgeting, gender-disaggregated data, sex-wise targets.
- Gender focal points, training of officials, women's participation at all levels.
- Complement with **women-specific programmes** (twin-track approach).



Women-specific	Mainstreaming
Targets women only	Integrates gender in all policies
Special schemes (e.g. SHGs)	Gender lens on roads, energy, health, IT
Short term	Long term, systemic

12. Objective and Long Questions

Q15. Quick recall

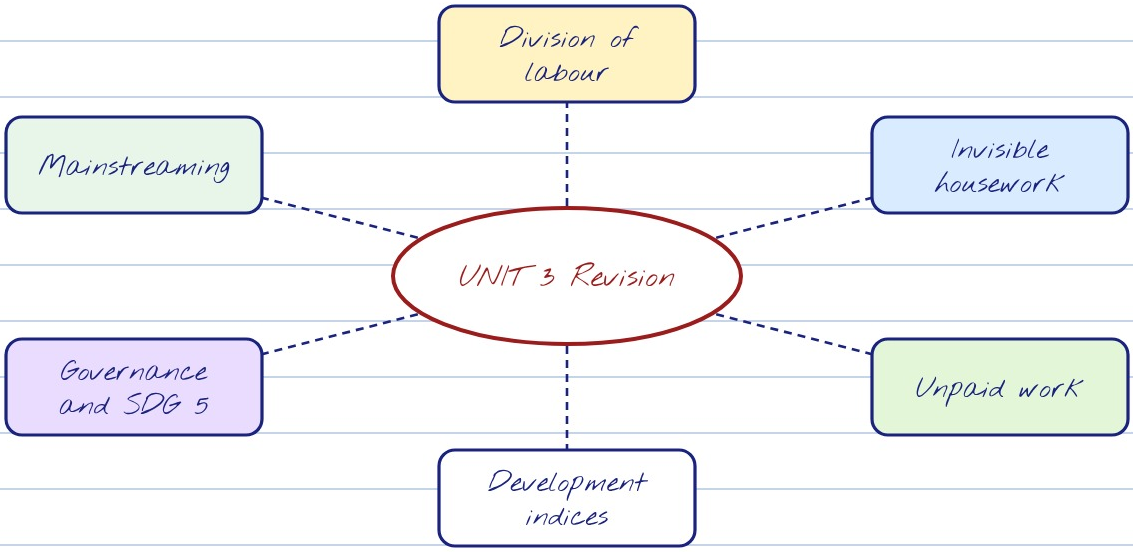
- 1. Unpaid household work is called **invisible labour**. 2. Glass ceiling = **vertical segregation**.
- 3. CEDAW adopted = **1979**. 4. India ratified CEDAW = **1993**. 5. SDG for gender equality = **SDG 5**.
- 6. Mainstreaming defined by **ECOSOC (1997)**. 7. Maternity leave now = **26 weeks**.

Q16. Long answers

- 1. Explain division and valuation of labour with examples. (Sec. 1)
- 2. Housework as invisible labour; discuss "My Mother Doesn't Work" and "Share the Load". (Sec. 2–4)
- 3. Unrecognised and unaccounted work; politics and economics of work. (Sec. 5, 6, 10)
- 4. Gender, governance, sustainable development, human rights and mainstreaming. (Sec. 8–11)

What is not counted does not count – make care work visible, valued and shared.

13. Two-Mark Questions and Quick Revision



Q17. Two-mark questions

> 1. **Gender division of labour** : tasks assigned to women and men on the basis of gender.
> 2. **Double burden** : paid work plus unpaid household work.
> 3. **Informal sector** : work without contract, social security or legal protection.
> 4. **Glass ceiling** : invisible barrier to promotion of women.
> 5. **Gender budgeting** : analysing budgets for their effect on women and men.
> 6. **GII** : Gender Inequality Index (health, empowerment, labour market).
> 7. **Mainstreaming** : bringing a gender perspective into all policies and programmes.
> 8. **Twin-track approach** : mainstreaming plus women-specific programmes.

Concept	One-line memory aid
Productive work	Paid, counted, valued
Reproductive work	Unpaid, uncounted, undervalued
Mainstreaming	Gender lens on EVERY policy
SDG 5	Gender equality and empowerment